

The Ontological Divide in Ancient Israelite Religion: Isaiah, Deuteronomy 32, and the Pluralistic Framework of Latter-day Saint Theology

Monolatry, Monotheism, Polytheism, Trinitarianism

I. Introduction: Defining the Textual and Theological Conflict

The historical development of monotheism within ancient Israel remains one of the most vigorously debated topics in biblical scholarship. This report addresses the fundamental tension arising from two foundational textual corpora: the oldest known versions of the writings of Moses, specifically the Song of Moses in Deuteronomy 32, and the uncompromising declarations of ontological singularity found in Deutero-Isaiah (Isaiah 40–55). A rigorous analysis of the textual variants in Deuteronomy 32:8-9 reveals a pre-monotheistic cosmology—the Divine Council—that is inherently incompatible with Isaiah's claim that no other true gods exist.

The central premise of this analysis is that the historical trajectory of Israelite religion moved from a hierarchical, pluralistic celestial worldview to a strict, numerical monotheism, a shift evident in scribal interventions within the biblical text itself. This report employs a historical-critical approach to reconstruct the original meaning of Deuteronomy, juxtaposing it with the theological demands of Isaiah. The final stage of the analysis examines how Latter-day Saint (LDS) theology, with its doctrines of plurality and the Godhead, uniquely interacts with and potentially resolves this ancient biblical conflict by affirming the cosmological reality implied by the oldest textual evidence of Deuteronomy while re-contextualizing Isaiah's claims as statements of incomparable sovereignty and exclusive devotion.

II. Deuteronomy 32: The Divine Council and Territorial Divinity

2.1. The Song of Moses: Historical and Literary Context

The Song of Moses (Deuteronomy 32:1-43) is widely recognized by scholars as a highly archaic piece of poetic literature, containing linguistic and morphological features suggesting its composition predates the later, monotheizing redactions often associated with the Deuteronomistic History. Its language and themes share significant overlap with Northwest Semitic literature, particularly Ugaritic texts, reinforcing its representation of early Israelite tradition. This antiquity is crucial because it suggests the cosmology preserved here reflects a phase of Israelite belief prior to the adoption of strict monotheism.

2.2. Textual Critical Analysis of Deuteronomy 32:8-9

The core theological dilemma resides in Deuteronomy 32:8, which describes how the Most High divided humanity. The specific phrase used to account for this division varies significantly across the three principal manuscript traditions, each reflecting a major stage in the theological development of Judaism.

The standard text used in later Jewish tradition, the **Masoretic Text (MT)**, reads *l'mispar b'nei Yisrael* ("according to the number of the sons of Israel"). Traditional commentators, such as Rashi and Pseudo-Jonathan, harmonized this reading by linking it typologically to the seventy sons of Jacob who went down to Egypt (Genesis 46). This reading numerically aligns Israel's foundational number with the estimated number of Gentile nations, but it obscures the original cosmological message of the verse.

By contrast, the **Dead Sea Scrolls (DSS)**, specifically the Qumran manuscript (4QDeut^aj⁸), provide what textual critics overwhelmingly agree is the superior and older reading: *l'mispar b'nei Elohim* ("according to the number of the sons of God/gods"). This variant carries immense theological weight because it explicitly introduces divine multiplicity into the celestial arrangement presided over by Elyon.

The **Septuagint (LXX)**, the ancient Greek translation, offers an interpretive middle ground, often translating the phrase as *aggelón theou* ("according to the number of the angels of God"). This translation strategy reflects an early post-Exilic attempt to manage the theological implications of *b'nei Elohim*. By demoting these heavenly beings from genuine "gods" to created, non-divine "angels," later interpreters retained the idea of a heavenly administration while safeguarding YHWH's unique status.

The existence of these three major variants concerning a single phrase demonstrates a discernible historical trajectory of theological censorship. The shift from *b'nei Elohim* (DSS) to *aggelón theou* (LXX) to *b'nei Yisrael* (MT) illustrates the progressive difficulty later monotheists faced in integrating the concept of rival or subordinate deities into their theology. The Masoretic Text's final reading is a clear **effect** of a matured, strict monotheism actively purging polytheistic remnants, confirming that the original meaning, depicting divine plurality, was consciously recognized as a theological problem requiring redaction.

Table 1: Deuteronomy 32:8 Textual Variants and Theological Implications

Textual Tradition	Reading of Deut 32:8	Theological Interpretation	Historical Context of Transmission
Masoretic Text (MT)	<i>b'nei Yisrael</i> (Sons of Israel)	Avoidance of divine multiplicity; Numerical and typological reading	Late Second Temple/Rabbinic Period; Post-Isaian Monotheism
Dead Sea Scrolls (DSS)	<i>b'nei Elohim</i> (Sons of God/gods)	Explicit Divine Council; Subordinate deities assigned territorial rule	Pre-monotheistic or Monolatrous Period (archaic text)
Septuagint (LXX)	<i>aggelón theou</i> (Angels of God)	Harmonization; Demotion of deities to created, non-divine angelic agents	Second Temple Period; Integration into emerging strict Monotheism

2.3. The Divine Allotment and Cosmological Implications

Interpreting the older, restored reading (*b'nei Elohim*) establishes a clear Ancient Near Eastern (ANE) cosmology. The text depicts *Elyon* (The Most High) assigning the Gentile nations as an inheritance to the *b'nei Elohim*. Crucially, *Yahweh* (YHWH) reserves Israel (Jacob) as his

exclusive portion. This arrangement suggests a hierarchy in which YHWH, though often identified with Elyon in other poetic texts (e.g., Psalm 92:1), functions within a celestial governance structure.

The cosmological implication is that the *b'nei Elohim* serve as subordinate, delegated divine beings assigned specific territorial jurisdiction over the nations. This system of shared dominion, administered by divine agents, became a key model in later Jewish thought, even as the "gods" were demoted to "protective angels" for the nations (cf. Daniel 10:13). The point of Deuteronomy 32:8–9 is not merely creation, but the sovereign act of YHWH rejecting direct rule over rebellious humanity and placing them under the authority of these lesser divine beings, a policy for which these beings were later judged (as seen in Psalm 82).

2.4. Monolatry vs. Monotheism in Deuteronomy

The theological framework reflected in the Song of Moses is best classified as **monolatry** or **henotheism**, not strict monotheism. Monolatry involves the exclusive worship of one God (YHWH) while acknowledging the existence of other deities. Deuteronomy 32 provides further evidence for this distinction. While verses 8-9 establish the existence of other gods, verses such as 32:12 and 32:39 affirm that there is no god "with" YHWH, meaning no god who acts on Israel's behalf.

This is a functional denial of the significance or salvific power of other gods, rather than an ontological denial of their existence. The passage often designates these rival deities as *b'lo-e/* ("non-gods"). They are not conceptualized as non-existent, but rather as beings who are inconsequential, powerless, or worthless in comparison to YHWH. Therefore, the tension inherent in the archaic text is not one of ontological conflict, but of sociological exclusivity: other divine beings exist, but YHWH alone is Israel's legitimate object of worship and source of salvation.

III. Deutero-Isaiah: The Triumph of Ontological Monotheism

3.1. The Exilic Context and Prophetic Polemic

The writings of Deutero-Isaiah (Isaiah 40–55) are traditionally situated during the Babylonian Exile, a critical period when Israel's national and religious identity was threatened by the overwhelming power and pantheons of the Mesopotamian empire. This historical crisis provided the theological impetus for the development of an uncompromising, absolute monotheism designed to delegitimize the deities of the conquerors.

3.2. Declarations of Absolute Uniqueness (Numerical Monotheism)

Deutero-Isaiah is consistently highlighted in scholarship as the canonical work that achieves "strict," "radical," or "pure" monotheism, moving definitively beyond the monolatry or henotheism of earlier texts. This prophetic work explicitly transitions from a covenantal command to worship YHWH alone toward a universal, ontological claim about the nature of reality.

The core of this doctrine lies in **explicit ontological denial**. Passages such as Isaiah 43:10, 44:6, and 45:5-6 assert that YHWH is the exclusive and sole member of the class of true deity: "I am the LORD, and there is no other; there is no God but Me". This denial is absolute, extending even temporally: YHWH claims temporal singularity, stating, "No god was formed before Me, and there will be none after Me". The rhetorical strategy involves mocking the idols and asserting YHWH's incomparable status based on His unique roles as Creator, ultimate Savior, and sole source of true prophecy. These claims function to abolish any notion of rival or

even subordinate divine entities.

3.3. The Conflict: Ontological Annihilation of the Divine Council

The confrontation between Deutero-Isaiah's ontological singularity and the cosmological plurality found in the oldest reading of Deuteronomy 32 is not merely a difference in emphasis but a **fundamental ontological rift**. If Deuteronomy 32 (DSS) establishes the real, existing nature of subordinate, territorial *elohim*, Isaiah's systematic denial necessitates that these entities must be ontologically non-existent.

The development of monotheism in Israel required a shift from *einheit* (the oneness of devotion, or monolatry, accepted in Deuteronomy 32) to *einzigheit* (the uniqueness of existence, or numerical monotheism, demanded by Isaiah 40–55). This demand for absolute singularity forced Jewish tradition to resolve the Divine Council concept. The primary theological move of the post-Exilic period was the elimination of the Divine Council concept from standard interpretation, replacing it with the non-divine roles of angels or, as seen in the MT, excising the problematic pluralistic language entirely. The Isaian rhetoric thus serves as the yardstick against which the "rigor and maturity" of monotheism in the rest of the Hebrew Bible is often evaluated.

3.4. Critiques and Contextual Reading of Isaian Monotheism

While the dominant scholarly view holds that Deutero-Isaiah champions absolute monotheism, some critical viewpoints suggest the language may not be as unique as claimed. It is noted that similar polemical rhetoric—claiming to be "the only one, none beside me"—was used in claims made by high-gods of other ANE cultures, such as Marduk in Babylonian incantations. However, the consensus maintains that the sheer scope, consistency, and contextual placement of Isaiah's denials represent a pivotal shift. The prophetic author's insistence on YHWH as the *uncreated cause* and the absolute boundary-marker for deity ("No god was formed before Me") establishes a form of theoretical monotheism unparalleled in earlier biblical writings. This strict ontological commitment defined the parameters for subsequent Jewish and Christian thought, ensuring that the pluralistic elements of texts like Deuteronomy 32 could only be retained through linguistic demotion (e.g., from gods to angels).

IV. Historical and Theological Synthesis: Bridging the Divide

4.1. The Developmental Model and the Problem of Nomenclature

The textual analysis confirms a developmental model in Israelite religion, moving from an early ANE-influenced cosmology (Deuteronomy 32) through judicial monolatry (where YHWH presides and judges the lesser *elohim* in Psalm 82) to the strict monotheism of the Exilic period (Isaiah 40–55).

This evolution makes precise theological nomenclature problematic. Scholars have coined terms like "inclusive monotheism" or "tolerant monolatry" to classify Israelite belief, struggling to define a system that simultaneously condemns the worship of other gods while acknowledging their existence and function. The difficulty arises because "monotheism" is a modern term, initially popularized in the Enlightenment as an antonym to "atheism," not necessarily "polytheism". Defining the biblical God concept, therefore, requires accounting for the "clear evidence of polytheism in the Hebrew Bible" while recognizing the crucial difference Israelite religion posed to its environment.

4.2. Scribal Harmonization: From Gods to Angels

The most common mechanism used to resolve the conflict between Deuteronomy 32 and Isaiah was the process of theological neutralization, often through the demotion of divine status.

The shift of the *b'nei Elohim* to *aggelón theou* (angels) in the Septuagint translation served as a critical theological refinement. This angelology allowed later interpreters to explain the heavenly administration described in Deuteronomy 32 and Psalm 82 without violating the strict ontological monotheism demanded by Isaiah. By transforming the *elohim* into created, non-divine servants of YHWH, the heavenly hierarchy was preserved, but YHWH remained the sole, uncreated ontological deity. This development was crucial in early Judaism and paved the way for early Christian understanding of the heavenly realm.

The Divine Council, as depicted in Psalm 82, acts as a pivotal judicial midpoint. The Psalm affirms the existence of the council where YHWH stands and judges the *elohim*. The subsequent decree that they "shall die like men" establishes YHWH's supreme authority to hold them accountable, justifying their replacement or functional demotion in later theology. This narrative provided a theological framework for explaining why the formerly powerful territorial gods (Deut 32) were now understood as mere subservient angels or, worse, judged and failing entities.

4.3. The Enduring Hermeneutical Problem

The inherent difficulty in harmonizing these texts within traditional monotheism lies in the nature of the contradiction. Orthodox interpretations must either argue that Deuteronomy 32 (DSS reading) reflects an archaic, discarded theology that should be ignored or amended, or that Isaiah's claims of singularity are merely rhetorical exaggeration, not literal ontological statements. Neither approach fully accounts for the evident textual history and the distinct theological aims of each corpus. The conflict persists because one tradition (Deut 32) demands plurality for its cosmology to function, while the other (Isa 40–55) demands singularity for its polemic to succeed.

V. Latter-day Saint Theology: A Pluralistic Interpretation

5.1. The LDS Conception of the Godhead and Plurality

LDS theology, rooted in the revelations received by Joseph Smith, offers a unique conceptual framework that radically diverges from post-Nicene Christian and Rabbinic Jewish monotheism. The LDS doctrine affirms the numerical plurality of the Godhead: God the Father, Jesus Christ, and the Holy Ghost are understood as three distinct, separate personages. The Father and the Son possess tangible, glorified bodies of flesh and bones, rejecting the traditional Trinitarian doctrine of a shared, non-physical substance.

Furthermore, LDS teachings emphasize eternal progression. Joseph Smith taught that "God himself; the Father of us all dwelt on an earth the same as Jesus Christ himself did" and that humankind is intended to "learn how to be Gods yourselves; to be kings and priests to God, the same as all Gods have done". This premise implies not only a plurality within the Godhead but an eternal system of exalted beings who have achieved godhood, thereby making the existence of multiple, organized, and powerful deities a core ontological truth.

5.2. The Restored Divine Council (The Book of Abraham)

Crucially, LDS scripture explicitly validates the cosmological reality that the MT scribes worked

to erase: the existence of a formal Divine Council structure. The Book of Abraham, a text translated by Joseph Smith, details a creation account where "the Gods" "took counsel among themselves".

This restored council is hierarchical, composed of "intelligences," "noble and great ones," "God" (the Father), "one... that was like unto God" (Jesus Christ), and "another" who was "second" to Christ. This structure aligns directly with scholarly interpretations of the ANE Divine Council, where a supreme God (Elyon/Father) presides over organized, subordinate divine beings. This restored council concept provides an ontological home for the *b'nei Elohim* of Deuteronomy 32. These beings are not viewed as pagan remnants or simple idols, but as legitimate, organized, and delegated members of the heavenly host, affirming the core functional truth of the ancient text. The structure of *Elyon* presiding over the *b'nei Elohim* is viewed as analogous to the Father presiding over other exalted intelligences who organize and govern.

5.3. LDS Interpretation of Deuteronomy 32 and Isaiah

LDS theology resolves the ancient biblical tension by adopting the ontological framework of the oldest biblical texts (Deuteronomy 32, DSS) and redefining the scope of the radical monotheistic claims (Isaiah 40–55).

The LDS framework provides a validation for Deuteronomy 32, seeing the delegation of nations to lesser gods as a real, historical divine policy, consistent with an eternally organized cosmos governed by a council.

The declarations of exclusivity in Isaiah must, therefore, be reinterpreted as powerful, but ultimately **relational and polemical statements of incomparability and exclusivity of worship**, rather than numerical denial. If the plurality of Gods is an eternal truth established by modern revelation, then Isaiah's cry, "there is no other god besides me," cannot mean absolute non-existence. Instead, it is interpreted to mean: "There is no other God who has the authority, covenantal relationship, or power sufficient to save Israel, and therefore Israel must worship only YHWH".

The LDS approach shifts the concept of monotheism from **numerical singularity** to **relational singularity** or **exclusive devotion**. This view suggests that the theological maturation reflected in the Bible was not the realization that other gods *did not exist*, but the crucial covenantal realization that these other existing divine beings were utterly *irrelevant* to Israel's salvation, and thus functionally nonexistent (*b'lo-el*), leading to the prophetic denial and historical redaction. This hermeneutic allows both Deuteronomy 32 and Isaiah 40–55 to retain their structural integrity and unique theological functions within a single, cohesive cosmological model.

Table 2: Comparative Theological Alignment on Divine Ontology

Concept	Deuteronomy 32:8 (Original DSS)	Deutero-Isaiah (Traditional Monotheistic View)	LDS Theology (Restored Doctrine)
Supreme Deity	Elyon/YHWH is Most High, head of the council	YHWH is Ontologically Singular/Incomparable	Heavenly Father is Supreme and Eternal
Ontology of Other Divine Beings	Explicitly assumes <i>b'nei Elohim</i> (Subordinate, Territorial Gods)	Explicitly denies ontological existence ("no God but Me"); Rivals are non-existent idols	Affirms plurality of Gods (Gods, intelligences, exalted beings) who possess real existence
Cosmological Structure	Divine Council allocates nations	None; YHWH is sole creator/actor	Heavenly Council organizes creation and salvation (Book of

Concept	Deuteronomy 32:8 (Original DSS)	Deutero-Isaiah (Traditional Monotheistic View)	LDS Theology (Restored Doctrine)
			Abraham)
Resolution of Tension	Problem requires harmonization (MT/LXX) or acceptance as archaic polytheism.	Problem requires dismissal of Deut 32 as non-monotheistic or rhetorical.	Tension is resolved by interpreting Isaiah as functional exclusivity (Monolatry) within an ontologically plural universe (Pluralism).

VI. Conclusion: Tension, Synthesis, and Comparative Value

The historical analysis of Deuteronomy 32 and Isaiah 40–55 confirms that the Hebrew Bible contains a demonstrable theological tension rooted in opposing cosmological viewpoints. The oldest available textual evidence (DSS) for Deuteronomy 32:8-9 mandates a pluralistic, hierarchical Divine Council structure, a concept fundamentally incompatible with the developed, radical monotheism articulated in Deutero-Isaiah. The transmission history of the text—the active redaction of *b’nei Elohim* to *b’nei Yisrael*—serves as a concrete documentation of historical Judaism's necessity to enforce ontological singularity by purging polytheistic remnants. The LDS theological framework offers a powerful comparative lens for this conflict. By embracing the doctrines of plurality and an eternal, active Divine Council, LDS theology validates the archaic cosmology of Deuteronomy 32, providing an organized, non-pagan structure for the existence and function of the *b’nei Elohim*. Concurrently, this perspective allows for a nuanced reading of Isaiah’s monotheistic polemics, understanding them as unsurpassed declarations of YHWH's **incomparability and exclusive claim to Israel's devotion and worship**, rather than a denial of all other divine existence.

This comparative approach achieves a profound theological synthesis: it honors the textual complexity and antiquity of both Deuteronomy 32 and Isaiah 40–55, resolving the ontological conflict that traditional monotheistic readings have historically struggled to reconcile without textual emendation or rhetorical dismissal. The LDS perspective suggests that the critical shift in Israelite religion was not merely evolutionary but a specific, covenantal refinement of worship, where ontological reality (plurality) was subsumed by the necessity of exclusive relational focus (monolatry), precisely to solidify Israel's identity against the competing gods of the nations.

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